The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran said its control over the Strait of Hormuz was “being stabilised” after it exchanged strikes with **America** in the vital waterway. On Monday Donald Trump announced America would begin guiding neutral ships through the strait. The country subsequently destroyed seven Iranian boats, while Iran launched missiles at American vessels. Oil prices remained high after soaring on Monday.

Vladimir Putin declared a two-day **ceasefire** with **Ukraine**, which will start on May 8th to mark Russia’s victory in the second world war. The Kremlin warned Ukraine that violating the truce would trigger a “massive missile strike”. But Ukraine claimed it had not received a proposal and said it would observe its own two-day ceasefire from May 5th.

Narendra Modi, **India’s** prime minister, hailed “historic and unprecedented” state election results after his Bharatiya Janata Party swept to victory in West Bengal, formerly an opposition stronghold. Mr Modi insisted the result was a triumph for “democratic processes”, despite accusations that his party influenced institutions to tilt elections in its favour. The BJP and its allies now run 22 of India’s 31 states and territories.

An explosion at a fireworks factory in **China's** Hunan province killed 21 people and injured 61, according to state media. People living within 3km of the blast were evacuated; two nearby gunpowder factories remained a risk, authorities said. President Xi Jinping said there would be a full investigation and that those responsible for the disaster would be held to account.

Hugo Boss's first-quarter operating profits fell by 42% year on year to €35m ($40m), beating analysts' expectations. The German fashion house's chief executive said it had a "clear direction" despite a "challenging" environment. The company has suffered from declining footfall in its Middle Eastern stores because of the war in Iran. The region accounted for around 3% of total revenue last year.

A car drove into a crowd in **Leipzig** in eastern Germany, killing at least two people and seriously injuring three. A suspect has been arrested. Burkhard Jung, the city's mayor, said there is "no longer any danger" and that a motive is not yet known. Similar ramming incidents have killed several people in Germany in recent years.

Wu Yize won the **World Snooker Championship**, defeating Shaun Murphy by 18 frames to 17 in a thrilling final. The 22-year-old is the second-youngest player to hold the sport's biggest title. Mr Wu is also the second consecutive world champion from China, which has become a snooker superpower in recent years.

Figure of the day: $1,500, the price Rwanda charges per person to see its mountain gorillas. Read our report on how to save the safari.

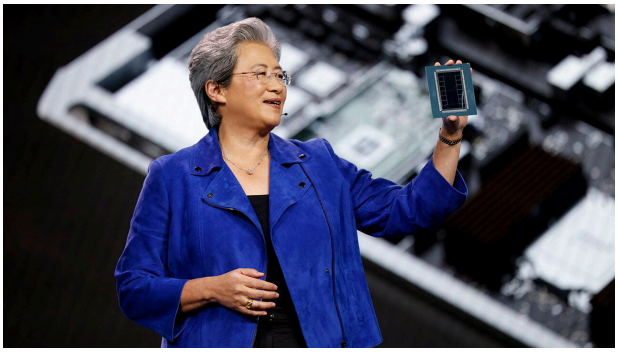
Photograph: Getty Images

UniCredit launches offer for Commerzbank

Shortly after Italy's UniCredit published its offer to take over Commerzbank, Germany's second-largest bank, at a €35bn ($40bn) valuation, the bank reported record quarterly revenue. The deal has been in the making since September 2024, when UniCredit bought 9% of Commerzbank's shares. Over subsequent months, UniCredit built a stake worth roughly 30% in the German bank.

The bid has been met with resistance in Germany, from both unions and the government, which owns 12% of Commerzbank. Its bosses are opposed, too. Bettina Orlopp, its chief executive, argues the offer is in the interest of neither Commerzbank's shareholders nor its clients. On May 8th she will present Commerzbank's quarterly results, alongside a strategic plan.

Andrea Orcel, UniCredit's boss, is undeterred. He maintains that the acquisition is inevitable, arguing that potential synergies from UniCredit's German subsidiary, HypoVereinsbank, make the Italian bank the most suitable buyer. Mr Orcel hopes the tie-up will create a more profitable European powerhouse. Ms Orlopp has three days to set out her case and shareholders have four weeks to decide.



Photograph: Getty Images

AMD is thriving in Nvidia's shadow

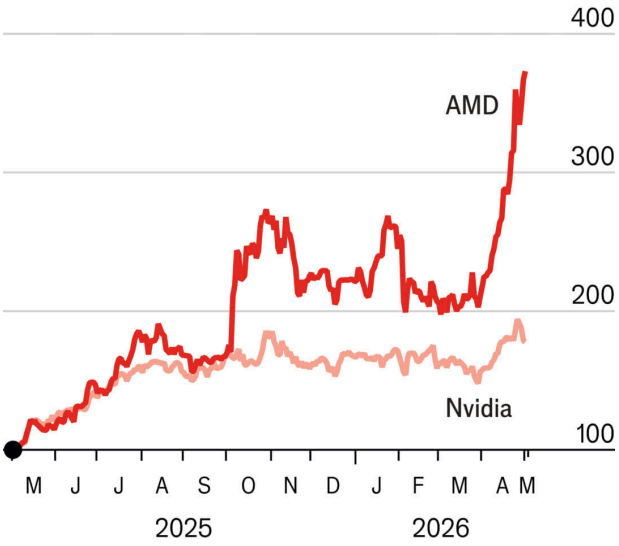
The share price of AMD, an American chip designer that reports first-quarter earnings on Tuesday, has risen by 270% over the past year. That is more than three times the rise of Nvidia, its bigger rival.

AMD's flourishing fortune rests on two types of chips. The rise of "agentic" AI—software that uses reason to solve problems and perform complex tasks—has renewed demand for central processing units used in PCs and servers. AMD accounts for about a third of the market for CPUs used in data centres.

The second is specialist AI chips, where Nvidia remains dominant. AMD's offerings are narrower, but it is winning business through creative dealmaking. In February it reached a multi-year agreement with Meta, a social-media giant, to sell processors representing around six gigawatts of computing capacity. In return, Meta can acquire up to 10% of AMD's shares. AMD struck a similar deal with OpenAI in October. Investors will hope that the AI boom can last.

A chip above

Share prices, May 1st 2025=100



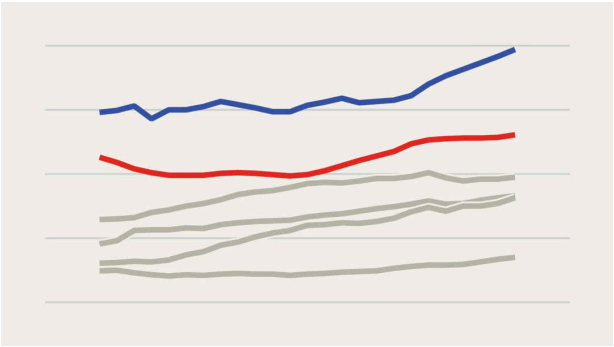
Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Getty Images

Will Romania's prime minister fall?

In May last year, Nicusor Dan won Romania's presidential election. The centrist anti-corruption campaigner defeated George Simion, a MAGA-loving nationalist opposed to aiding Ukraine. Mr Dan's victory cheered the continent's liberals. But his time in office has been difficult. Romania has the biggest budget deficit in the European Union. A grand coalition of mainstream parties, which makes up the government, has struggled to agree on spending cuts.

On Tuesday MPs from the centre-left Social Democratic Party, which pulled out of the coalition in April, will join Mr Simion's Alliance for the Union of Romanians in a vote of no confidence against the prime minister, Ilie Bolojan. The fallout from the vote could prevent Romania from getting €11.4bn ($13.4bn) in EU funds, which the bloc has made conditional on economic reform. It will not lead to Mr Simion becoming prime minister: Mr Dan will not appoint him. But the coalition's infighting could further fuel Romanians' dissatisfaction with the traditional parties—and support for Mr Simion.



Photograph:

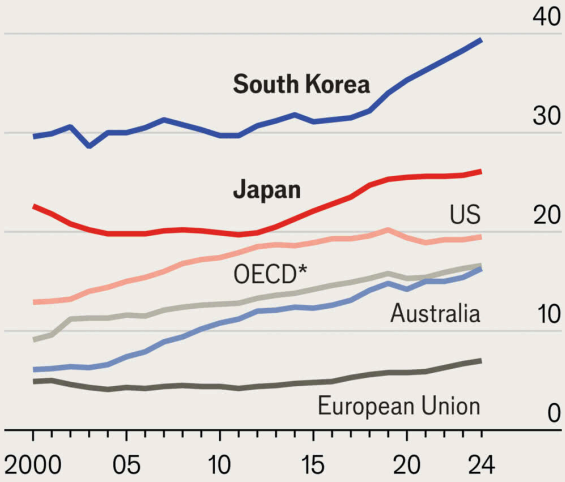
Data bite: East Asia’s ageing workers

Across the OECD, a club of mostly rich countries, Japan and South Korea have the largest proportion of people over the age of 65 who are still employed. Nearly 40% of elderly South Koreans and more than 25% of those in Japan remain at work.

Many work out of financial necessity. Some use employment to stave off health problems and keep loneliness at bay. However widespread discrimination and a high demand for low-skilled labour often leave them with unappealing choices. Policymakers have a strong incentive to act: keeping older people in work longer helps offset shrinking numbers of young people in both countries. Read the full story.

Working late

Labour-force participation rate, aged 65 and over %



*Weighted average

Source: OECD

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: John Fogerty was the main songwriter of which rock group?

Monday: Which prog rock group was founded by Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Waters and Richard Wright?

Life can only be understood backwards; but it must be lived forwards.

Soren Kierkegaard